

Now for the HARD PART

Having won a second term convincingly, Rajapaksa has to deliver on the economy and a new deal for the Tamils

| By Namini Wijedasa in Colombo |

The pundits had predicted a photo finish. But in the end President Mahinda Rajapaksa secured a second term by an astounding margin over his chief opponent, retired army commander Sarath Fonseka. Rajapaksa, who called the election two years early to capitalise on his Government's victory over the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) in May 2009—won 57.88 per cent of the vote while Fonseka polled 40.15 per cent. "I don't think even the Government expected such a win," said Muthukrishna Sarvananthan, an economist and researcher.

The results did surpass Rajapaksa's expectations and gave the confident opposition parties backing Fonseka a severe knocking. Rejecting the outcome, Fonseka said he would institute legal proceedings to have the results annulled on several grounds, including Rajapaksa's alleged abuse of state media and public resources for campaign purposes. Indeed, misuse of public resources had been a recurring theme of the former army chief's campaign. Backed by some of the most established political parties in Sri Lanka—including the main opposition United National Party (UNP), Sri Lanka Muslim Congress and, later, the Tamil National Alliance—Fonseka's campaign team had also attacked corruption in President Rajapaksa's regime, nepotism and cronyism. With no track

record in politics, Fonseka ladled out pledges with a generous spoon. He extravagantly vowed to increase the salaries of public sector employees by Rs 10,000 to raise the dole paid to Sri Lankans below the poverty line and to slash taxes. He tried to win the Tamils over by promising to normalise their lives and end their alienation.

Rajapaksa though outdid Fonseka by taking out a series of populist initiatives in the run-up to the election. He opened up roads that had been closed for security reasons, did away with checkpoints and permitted freedom of movement to displaced Tamils interned for months in camps. He hurriedly inaugurated overhead bridges and other public facilities and took measures to reduce the cost of essential items including slashing fuel prices. While these measures are likely to have played some part in his convincing electoral victory, it was mostly the "gratitude" factor that swayed Sri Lankans in Rajapaksa's favour. Vox populi surveys conducted in rural areas showed that the public still felt indebted to the President for his leadership in eliminating the LTTE. Their children could leave for school in the morning, many said, and be confident

of getting back alive. There were no bombs on buses, claymores on roadsides or suicide cadres lurking amongst them, poised to wreak death and destruction.

But Fonseka also played this trump card, neutralising Rajapaksa's efforts to take the credit. The intrepid soldier had engineered the arduous ground battles against the Tigers and was a decorated war hero who had survived a suicide bombing to boot. His campaign never failed to remind the electorate of that. Mudslinging was also a key component of the electioneering. The whole bevy of political parties supporting Fonseka ridiculed the 'Rajapaksa royal family' while the

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